

It all started with an image that went viral at the peak of the COVID-19 lockdown in May 2020. In its stillness was the implied journey of a thousand miles. Mohammad Saiyub, a factory worker from Basti, Uttar Pradesh, was cradling his friend Amrit Kumar on the side of a highway. The latter's eyes were closed and he had just collapsed from a heatstroke—they were two of the tens of millions of interstate migrant labourers across India forced to walk home after the lockdown's sudden announcement left daily wagers in the lurch without any provisions for their journey home. Only Saiyub would make it to Basti alive, his friend a victim of the chaos and state-led apathy the country was plunged into.

Journalist and author Basharat Peer came across their photo and was struck by its emotional potency. He tracked Saiyub down and discovered a moving story about a bond between two young men on the fringes—one a Muslim, the other a Dalit, both of whom worked in factories in Surat. Peer's longform piece 'A Friendship, a Pandemic and a Death Beside the Highway' appeared in *The New York Times* and immediately caught the eye of Somen Mishra, head of creative development at Dharma Productions. He turned to friend and filmmaker Neeraj Ghaywan to discuss a possible screen adaptation—"it had a caste angle, a strong humanist lens and a friendship story," he said, one which he felt Hindi cinema hadn't seen in a long time. Ghaywan, who disclosed his Dalit identity in the aftermath of his acclaimed directorial debut, *Masaan*, was on board. Mishra signed on as producer and Dharma head honcho Karan Johar joined the team.

After a world premiere at Cannes that got a nine-minute standing ovation, *Homebound* finally arrived in cinemas on September 26 and is expected to drop on Netflix sometime in November to generate buzz for the Oscars, where it is India's official entry in the Best International Film category. "*Homebound* represents many people of India who are often overlooked by traditional media and cinema," Ghaywan told INDIA TODAY magazine in late September. "That it is India's entry to the Oscar is a moment for them to be seen, heard and felt."

BEHIND THE SCENES

It has taken Ghaywan nearly a decade to get his sophomore feature out. At first, his ideas revolved around a narrative on farmer suicides for which he interviewed many affected families, but the project fell through. The "politics was superseding the narrative", he says. He and Mishra had another project in development, written by Varun Grover, but it didn't materialise due to casting and budgetary woes. On this prolonged creative struggle, Ghaywan says, "The fight is with yourself, with your fractured identity, [with] what you want to say to the world.... The quest that makes you not settle for anything that's not making you get up in the morning and scream, wanting to make it."

That fire and hunger erupted in full force with the story of Saiyub and Kumar. "I [wanted to make a film to] see what they eat and love, go into their homes, see what their dreams are, how they are shattered, why do they arrive in bigger cities and go back at all," says Ghaywan.

He and Peer went on research trips to Uttar Pradesh and Surat to know more about the boys' lives, the spaces they inhabited and the socio-economic conditions they grew up in. Meanwhile, Dharma's legal team was chasing *The New York Times* to procure legal rights, which would finally come through in 10 months. Screenwriter Sumit Roy came on board to help Ghaywan with the story and plotting. Grover and actor Shreedhar Dubey, later also the dialect trainer, contributed with dialogues. But the biggest catch was legendary filmmaker Martin Scorsese boarding as executive producer. An admirer of *Masaan*, he had sent Ghaywan a note of appreciation and told the film's French creative producer Mélita Toscan du Plantie that he'd like to be a part of Ghaywan's next if ever an opportunity arose. Mentorship from a figure many deem Hollywood's greatest living director was a badge of honour indeed. Scorsese would offer valuable notes on the script and, during the editing stage, remind Ghaywan not to deviate from the film's core—friendship—so much so that Saiyub's love story was entirely cut out in order to make the narrative tighter.



"*Homebound* is a beautifully crafted film that's a significant contribution to Indian cinema"

MARTIN SCORSESE
Director